

Senior Leadership Team Effectiveness: A Case Study of NGOs in Nigeria

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Dissertation Proposal

I, Adeboye Oloyede, declare that I am the sole author of this assignment and the work is a result of my own investigations, except where otherwise stated.

All references have been duly cited.

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TABLE OF CONTENTS

1.0 INTRODUCTION	4
1.1 Research Question	5
1.2 Research Objectives.....	5
2.0 LITERATURE REVIEW	6
2.1 Team Effectiveness	6
2.2 Models of Team Effectiveness.....	7
2.3 Team Leadership.....	8
2.4 Leadership in NGOs	8
4.0 METHODOLOGY	10
5.0 TIMELINE.....	12
6.0 LIMITATIONS.....	13
REFERENCES	14

1.0 INTRODUCTION

Organizations are compelled to change to be able to survive and thrive in the current volatile, complex and uncertain operating environments (Balogun and Johnson 2005; Rainey 2006; Johnson, Scholes and Whittington 2008; Kriger and Zhovtobryukh 2013; Minciu, Berar and Dobrea 2020).

As a result, increasing attention is now being paid to the top team in the organization (Wageman et al. 2008; Taneja, Sewell and Pryor 2012; Hou and Fang 2016) due to the recognition of the fact that driving organizational performance in the current reality is complex and demands more than what a 'lone-star' leader can effectively provide (Kriger and Zhovtobryukh 2013; Colbert, Barrick and Bradley 2014). A Top Management Team or Senior Leadership Team (SLT) collectively provide strategic and functional leadership and drive the delivery of an organization's strategic objectives (Wageman et al. 2008; Taneja, Sewell and Pryor 2012; Colbert, Barrick and Bradley 2014; Guo, Pang and Li, W. 2018).

Non-governmental Organizations (NGOs) are broadly considered to be citizens-driven-non-profit and non-political organizations delivering critical socio-economic interventions (Dhakal 2002; Cecilia and Carranza 2016; Laraswati et al. 2020). Vakil (1997) highlighted the complexities of defining NGOs and proposed a taxonomy around orientation (charities, service, participation and empowerment) and level of operation (community-based, state, national and international).

There have been mixed research outcomes about the effectiveness of top management teams in literature and that they often fail in realizing their potentials (Edmondson, Roberto and Watkins 2003) particularly among NGOs. While some have reported their successes (Roberts 2000), others have reported their failure (Akbar Zaidi 1999).

Edmondson, Roberto and Watkins (2003) argued that the effective decision making of top management teams in organizations could be negatively affected by divergence of interest or information, which creates an asymmetric distribution of information and interests within the team.

This study seeks to explore these themes as it impacts on the effectiveness of senior leadership teams.

1.1 Research Question

The broad question that this study hopes to answer is, what are the factors that facilitate or inhibit senior leadership team effectiveness of nongovernmental organizations in Nigeria?

1.2 Research Objectives

Based on this question, the following are the objectives of the study:

- i. To critically review current literature on leadership team effectiveness with particular reference to NGOs
- ii. To profile the leadership team characteristics and qualities of the senior leadership teams being investigated.
- iii. To draw conclusions and make recommendations for enhancing senior leadership team effectiveness based on findings.

2.0 LITERATURE REVIEW

Having effective leadership teams presents a potentially beneficial opportunity for organizations because according to Hackman (2002) it increases capacity, capabilities, enhances the quality of decision-making and leads to better achievements of strategic objectives, in this instance, for the whole organization. Failure to get this right at the top portends wasted efforts, poor decision-making, silo-thinking, myopic jostling for resources and unnecessary power play (Katzenbach and Smith 1993; Buchanan and Huczynski 2010; Aldag and Kuzuhara 2015; Wheelan 2016). The satisfaction of the factors that make for effective teams in top management is critical as they hold immense power in determining the direction of the organization and the effectiveness of this group consequently impacts the organizational performance (Luce Matthews 1998).

2.1 Team Effectiveness

There are common themes in the definition of teams that serve as pointers to how teams can raise their effectiveness; factors such as common purpose, composition, cohesiveness, diversity, climate, processes, structure, leadership style and communication all (Katzenbach and Smith, D.K. 1993; Hackman 2002, 2004; Wing 2005; Salas, Cooke and Rosen 2008; Wageman et al. 2008; Taneja, Sewell and Pryor 2012; Mathieu et al. 2017) have been accepted as levers of team effectiveness.

Edmondson, Roberto and Watkins (2003) described team effectiveness as the extent to which the team's decision could move the group forward, sustain cohesiveness and commitment, and satisfy team members' desire for growth regardless of group dynamics. Mathieu et al. (2017, p.457) identified team composition a key driver of team effectiveness stating that it 'concerns how the combination of team members' characteristics relates to team process and outcomes'. Hence, effectiveness of a leadership team could be influenced by some demographic characteristics that contribute to group processes or dynamics. Some of these characteristics include, but not limited to, gender, education, personality (like cognitive, social and emotional intelligence), and cultural diversity (Kang, Yang and Rowley 2006) to mention a few.

2.2 Models of Team Effectiveness

Over the years there has been focus in research on team effectiveness (Mathieu et al. 2017) with a number of models of contributing factors advanced. There is not space to explore them all due to space but what follows is a summary of a few of the models.

Wageman Model

As a result of a study of over 120 senior leadership teams that are diverse in geographical location, size and industry, Wageman et al. (2008) developed a model of enabling conditions for leadership team effectiveness that was grouped into what they called The Essentials which comprise the conditions of being a real team, having the right people with a compelling direction; and The Enablers—a solid team structure within a supportive organizational context having access to competent team coaching.

Mathieu Model

Mathieu et al. (2017) advocated a framework for gauging team effectiveness at multilevel and multiple constituencies dimension arguing that team effectiveness can only be measured based on context with consideration along: (a) team tasks and structure; (b) member characteristics and team composition; and (c) team processes and emergent states

Hackman's conditions for team effectiveness

Hackman (2002) identified five key conditions for optimizing the effectiveness of teamwork; these are:

Condition 1: Real team which requires the satisfaction of four features be satisfied: (a) Team task (b) Bounded team (c) Delimited authority (d) Stability over time

Condition 2: A compelling direction that is clear challenging and meaningful picture of what the team need to achieve.

Condition 3: Enabling job structure reflected by (a) design of the work the team performs, (b) established norms of conduct, and (c) appropriateness of team composition in terms of size and diversity.

Condition 4: Supportive context provided (a) the reward system (b) information systems and (c) an educational system

Condition 5: Availability of team coaching in guiding the team's ability to address aspects of team interaction that affects effective teamwork.

The Katzenbach and Smith Model

Katzenbach and Smith (1993) model highlighted the factors of skills, accountability and commitment as a catalyst for team effectiveness measured in terms of performance results, collective work products and personal growth of individual team members.

A closer examination of these models shows similarities in terms of need for structure, right composition, real team and supportive context. Katzenbach and Smith (1993) outlines a good number of the factors even though expressed differently, however highlighted a set of outcome areas. Salas, Sims and Burke (2005) argued that most models of team effectiveness fail to account for it holistically, focusing either on team performance or team interaction dimensions of team effectiveness.

2.3 Team Leadership

According to Zaccaro, Rittman and Marks (2001, p.83) 'team leadership is essential for team effectiveness'. Much research has been done on the impact of leadership styles and approaches on teams and organizations (Zaccaro, Rittman and Marks 2001; Yukl 2002; Avolio, Walumbwa and Weber 2009; Northouse 2012; Kriger and Zhovtobryukh 2013; Mahembe and Engelbrecht 2013).

No doubt, leadership has huge implications for the effectiveness of any senior team. Çıraklar and Duygulu (2009) asserted that the interaction and resulting outcomes between these two factors cannot be said to be random; it requires 'thoughtful, mindful ways of leading teams to levels of excellence never experienced by poor leadership' (Wing 2005, p.5).

2.4 Leadership in NGOs

Failure of nonprofit organizations has been a major concern too, not only in academic literature but also in the socioeconomic and political development of many developing communities where governments have failed in no small measure (Akbar Zaidi 1999). The failure and even termination of NGOs has been linked to leadership team incapability and failure (Hailey and James 2004)

among other factors like political and economic pressures. This has raised concern about capacity building of NGO's leadership system. According to Hailey and James (2004) an added challenge is that leadership in NGOs has been a relatively less researched area than leadership in profit-oriented organizations, further suggesting that this is due to leadership in NGOs often being personalized in nature (Hailey and James 2004).

Apostu's (2013) review of leadership development and role in NGOs showed that leadership skill deficit is one of the major plagues of NGOs highlighting cultural influences on the leadership styles many NGOs adopt further noting that NGOs that find itself in a collectivistic culture tends to adopt a participative leadership style while those in a more individualistic culture, tend to be less participative in decision-making.

Expectedly, leadership development of NGOs was linked to the sustainability of NGOs. Often confronted with constantly changing social system, globalization, breakdown of social values, and technological changes if leaders of NGOs are not flexible enough, they will not be able to cope with these constant changes, the consequence of which will be the death of the organization (Hailey and James 2004; Arora 2012; Balogun, Hope Hailey and Gustafsson 2016).

Zhang et al. (2015) showed that leadership approach that is focused evenly on top management team members increased team effectiveness and organizational performance. Flood et al. (2000), also found that leadership styles was instrumental as a relational factor to top management team effectiveness in both direct and indirect ways.

4.0 METHODOLOGY

This study will be carried out from the philosophical position of pragmatism, adopting a concurrent mixed methods research design (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019) in exploring the interplay between these two phenomena.

The research will focus on charitable NGOs selected based on purposive sampling (Quinlan et al. 2015) of NGOs that are in either start-up or expansion stages (Srinivasan 2007; Andersson, Faulk and Stewart 2016) in their organizational lifecycles and are based in Lagos state and Federal Capital Territory, Abuja, Nigeria. Participants will be senior management executives of the NGOs.

Primary sources of evidence for the research objectives will be drawn from semi-structured interviews (Ng and Coakes 2014) with the CEOs. This approach is suited for the research because of the exploratory nature of the study (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019).

A total of 15 CEOs of charitable NGOs will be approached with an expectation of 70% - 80% response rate. The semi-structured interview will look at the perception of the CEOs on the impact of the factors that enhances or hinders their senior leadership team effectiveness. Given the current realities of a global pandemic, the one-to-one interviews will be carried out virtually using internet-mediated access (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019) and recorded. Apart from health safety this will help mitigate costs associated with travels and related logistics, time and mitigate geographical challenge (Quinlan et al. 2015).

Quinlan et al. (2015) highlighted the difficulty of accessing ‘powerful’ individuals such as my samples. Being a Pastor in an influential Church gives me the opportunity to use my network (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019) to get direct access to CEOs of these organizations.

The recording of the interviews will be transcribed, reviewed, data coded and scrutinized for themes and relationships (Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019).

At the same period, a survey will be administered to the senior leadership teams of these NGOs using google form, an online survey tool with the aim of getting at least 50% response rate from each team. This is done to so as to compare how both data set support each other providing a deeper understanding of the study ((Saunders, Lewis and Thornhill 2019). In addition,

triangulation help to overcome potential bias from the interviews, thus increasing validity and reliability of the study (Williamson and Johanson 2018).

5.0 TIMELINE

Week		Activity	End dates
Pre-Dissertation		Develop my proposal and submit to my supervisor	14/07/2020
1-3		Introduction	09/08/2020
3-7		Literature review	06/09/2020
5-9		Develop methodology & data collection instruments	20/09/2020
10-14		Fieldwork	25/10/2020
12-16		Data analysis & findings chapter	08/11/2020
17-19		Analysis & conclusions chapter	29/11/2020
18-21		Write abstract, proof read, final editing & submit	13/12/2020

6.0 LIMITATIONS

Some of the potential limitations of this research includes:

1. Challenges associated with internet-mediated access.
2. Respondents' answer being beclouded by their subjective interpretation of the aim of the study.
3. Considering that a small sample of NGOs are being studied, the transferability of the research finding may not be possible.
4. Employees and other stakeholders' (recipients, donors, employees, volunteers etc) perception of the effectiveness of the senior leadership teams of the NGOs researched may be rated differently.
5. Other unaccounted factors that may influence team effectiveness are isolated from this research as they are beyond the scope.

Limitation	Response
1. Internet-mediated access	Challenges with unstable internet connection can impinge on the interview experience. As much possible two time slots will be negotiated with each participant and care will be taken to ensure they are similar time of day and possibly times when participants will likely be in similar frame of mind. This will be helpful in the case of a really bad network connection issue.
2. Participant bias	This will be mitigated by building rapport and trust to encourage openness by diligently preparing for each interview and ensuring that the purpose of the study is carefully explained and understood. The interview settings will be carefully designed and as much as possible private to minimize distractions and protect confidentiality.
3. Transferability	A detailed documentation of the research design, approach and context will be done so as to enable others conduct similar research.
4. Other stakeholder views	A disclosure will be made on this as the study is focused on the team itself and not considering the assessment of people external it.
5. Other factors	Chances are that there may be other factors that may not have been uncovered by this study deliberately or indeliberately. This will be disclosed as well so that readers will bear in mind the scope of the study.

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